NOIS3 Challenge Playbook

How FedTech PMs lead a NOIS3 challenge from award to closeout. It covers the eleven workflows in every challenge, the steps in each, and where the client gives input or must approve.

CHALLENGE	**[Challenge name]**
TASK ORDER	**[NOIS3-XXX]**
CLIENT REVIEWER	**[COR name / agency]**
REVIEW WINDOW	**[X] business days per gate**

How PMs use this playbook

A NOIS3 task order is won on a proposal and delivered through eleven repeatable workflows. As PM, you own all eleven: the schedule, the client relationship and every approval gate. This playbook gives you the same map for every challenge, so nothing depends on memory and nothing reaches solvers without the right sign-off.

Share it with your outreach, operations and review leads, and with marketing, so every team works from the same steps. Each workflow opens with a section page of best practices, followed by its full step-by-step sheet.

1 · SCOPE

Start with the RFTP

Mark which workflows the SOW calls for. Strike the rest, and add any new one from the blank template.

2 · PLAN

Set the gates at kickoff

Agree the ground rules with the COR. Name a reviewer and review window for every orange gate, then build the schedule backward from public dates.

3 · RUN

Walk each sheet with the team

Before a workflow starts, review its sheet with the leads. Request blue inputs early, and hold work at each orange gate until sign-off.

4 · CLOSE

Report against the gates

Use the gate list below in monthly and stage-close reports. At closeout, hand the network and records to the agency.

How to read a workflow sheet

Steps run left to right and step down as the work moves forward. Each card's header band shows who controls that step.



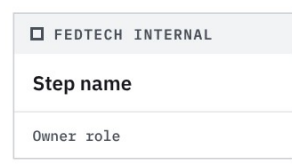
Approval gate

Work stops until the client signs off. The card names the deliverable being approved, so nobody signs off on something vague.



Client input

The step needs information, assets or a decision from the client. It doesn't need a formal sign-off. Ask early so the step doesn't stall.



FedTech internal

Our team owns this step from start to finish. The client sees the result at the next approval gate.

Every approval gate, by workflow

LAUNCH & VISIBILITY			
01	**Website build**	4 gates · 3 input	Sitemap → Copy & official rules → Visual design → Go-live
02	**Challenge.gov listing**	2 gates · 2 input	Listing content → Stage & winner updates
03	**Outreach & recruitment**	2 gates · 2 input	Outreach plan & KPIs → Messaging & content kit
04	**Info session build**	4 gates · 2 input	Agenda & speakers → Promotion copy → Slide deck → Recording & written Q&A
RUN THE COMPETITION			
05	**Competitor management**	3 gates · 2 input	Inbox & escalation rules → FAQ updates → Dispute resolutions
06	**Technical webinar**	3 gates · 1 input	Presenter lineup → Technical content → Written Q&A
07	**Judging & technical review**	2 gates · 2 input	Rubric & weights → Award decisions by federal judges
RESULTS & CLOSEOUT			
08	**Winner announcement**	1 gate · 1 input	Announcement content, cleared by agency public affairs
09	**In-person convening**	4 gates · 2 input	Venue & date → Agenda & speakers → Event materials → Recap content
10	**Reporting & closeout**	4 gates · 1 input	Project plan → Monthly reports → Stage-close reports → Final report
11	**Subcontractor management**	2 gates · 0 input	Named subcontractor at award → Any change to a sub, its scope or key staff
+	**Add a workflow**		Duplicate the blank template sheet for any workflow a task order adds.

Ground rules for client review

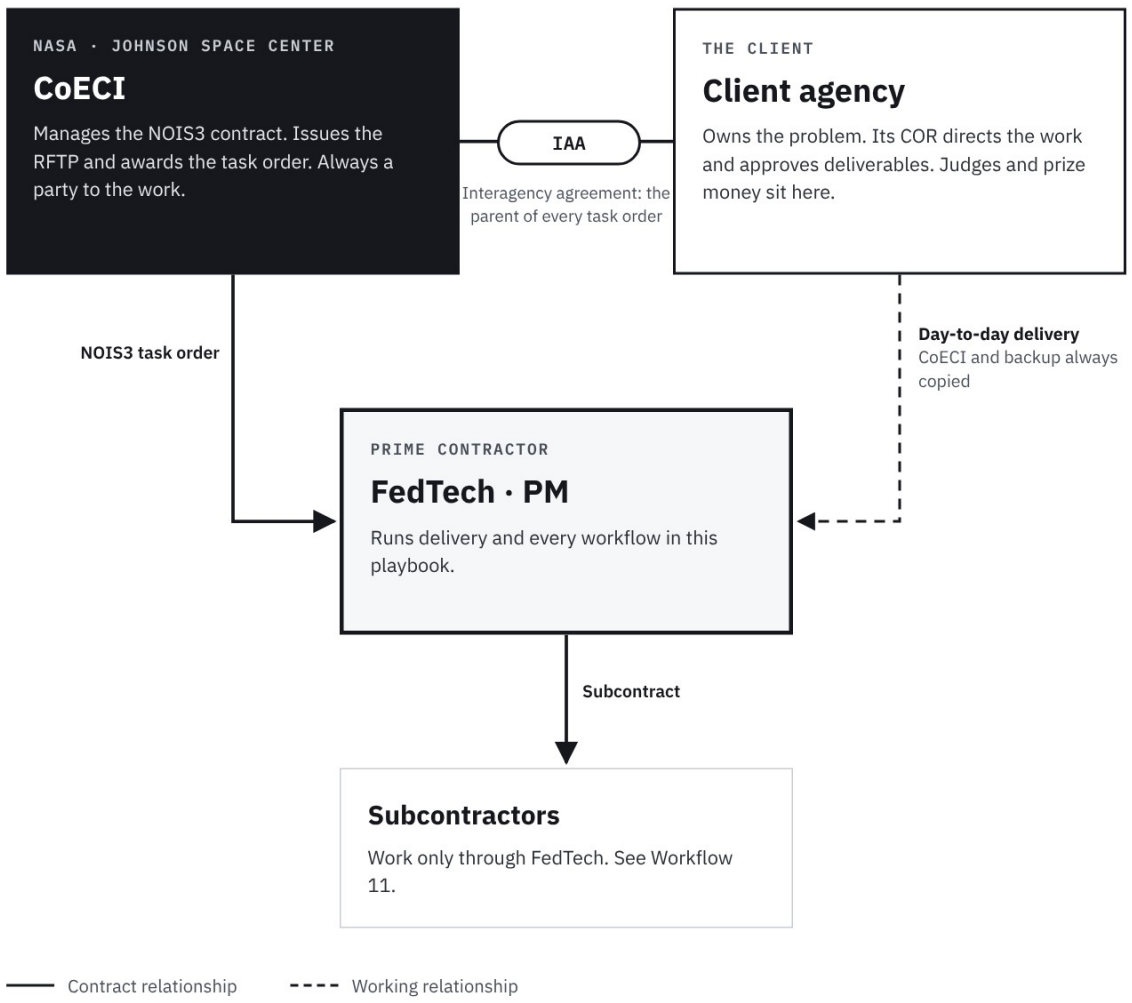
1. **Every gate has a named client reviewer and a fixed review window.** Both are set at kickoff and put in the schedule.
2. **One consolidated feedback round per gate.** A second round covers only changes we introduced while addressing the first.
3. **Nothing solver-facing goes public without its gate.** That includes site pages, Challenge.gov, promotions, decks, recordings and written answers.
4. **Anything said live is published in writing to every solver.** No team gains an advantage by attending a session.
5. **Section 508 accessibility is checked before anything goes public,** not fixed after launch.
6. **Rules, rubrics and platform are client-approved at least [30] days before each stage opens.** Confirm the exact lead time against each task order.
7. **Federal judges make every award decision.** FedTech, partners and SMEs advise and score; they never pick winners.
8. **CoECI and the backup CoECI contact are on every client communication.** Copied on every email and invited, at least as optional, to every meeting.

Based on the NOIS3-073 proposal and CoECI's stated expectations. Every task order's RFTP and SOW differ, so check each sheet against the current one and add or remove workflows to match.

BEFORE YOU START · THE CONTRACT BEHIND EVERY TASK ORDER

Where CoECI sits

NASA's Center of Excellence for Collaborative Innovation (CoECI), at Johnson Space Center, manages the NOIS3 contract. Every task order flows from an interagency agreement between CoECI and the client agency. That makes CoECI a material party to the work, even when it stays out of day-to-day delivery.



Rules for every PM

1. **Copy CoECI and the backup CoECI contact on every client communication.** Every email, and every meeting invite, at least as optional.
2. **Never sidestep CoECI, knowingly or not.** Above all on how the contract applies: scope, schedule, deliverables, acceptance and price.
3. **Treat CoECI as a material party to the task order.** It stays out of delivery when things go well. That is not the same as being out of the loop.
4. **Know the chain.** The interagency agreement between CoECI and the client agency is the parent. Our task order flows from it.
5. **The client agency's COR directs the work and approves deliverables.** Settle open questions with the COR in writing, with CoECI copied.

CoECI's six expectations

How CoECI expects FedTech to run every project, challenge or not.

01
Agenda 24 hours ahead
Before every call and every review touchpoint, recurring or not.

02
Notes within one business day
Every action item carries a name and a date.

03
Open with the schedule
Where we are and what's next. Two minutes that prevent drift.

04
Box links that don't expire
NASA defaults links to expire. Whoever sends a link turns expiry off, every time.

05
Name every owner
Each next step and each approval leaves the call with a named owner.

06
Book meetings live
Schedule follow-ups on the call itself, not over email.

When documents disagree, the signed schedule governs unless the client agrees otherwise in writing. Raise the conflict with the COR early, CoECI copied, rather than letting it drift. CoECI is open to practices we bring back.

THE CHALLENGE JOURNEY

Two journeys, one challenge

Solvers and the client move through the same challenge at the same time, wanting different things. The PM lane shows how we serve both. Where the solver and client lanes meet, our work is most visible.

- Participant (solver) journey
- Client (agency) journey
- FedTech PM focus
- Shared moment — Both lanes meet

	1 · LAUNCH & VISIBILITY			2 · RUN THE COMPETITION			3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT		
	01	02	03	04	05	06	07	08	09
LANE 1 — Participant What the solver does, and what they need from us	**Discover** Finds the challenge on Challenge.gov, through outreach or a partner post. **Needs:** a fast answer to "is this for me?"	**Learn** Reads the rules and FAQ, and joins the info session. **Needs:** plain answers, the same for everyone	**Register & team up** Registers and finds partners through matchmaking. **Needs:** easy sign-up and a way to meet collaborators	**Build** Develops the solution, asks questions and joins the technical webinar. **Needs:** fast, consistent answers	**Submit** Uploads the submission before the deadline. **Needs:** a reliable platform and reminders	**Wait for review** Waits while reviewers score and judges decide. **Needs:** a clear timeline and no surprises	**Hear results** Hears privately first, then sees the public announcement. **Needs:** timely, respectful notice, win or lose	**Showcase** Presents at the convening and meets funders and adopters. **Needs:** coaching and real introductions	**Move forward** Enters the next stage, or answers the post-award survey. **Needs:** a path beyond the prize
		Info session			Technical webinar			Announcement	Convening
LANE 2 — Client What the agency does, and the workflow behind it	**Kick off** Sets goals, names reviewers and agrees the approval gates. WF 10	**Approve launch** Signs off the site, official rules and Challenge.gov listing. WF 01 · 02	**Amplify** Shares through agency channels and speaks at the info session. WF 03 · 04	**Guide** Rules on policy and eligibility questions; clears webinar content. WF 05 · 06	**Set the bar** Approves the rubric and names federal judges. WF 07	**Decide** Federal judges select the winners. WF 07	**Announce** Public affairs clears and releases the results. WF 08	**Convene** Leadership meets winners, funders and partners. WF 09	**Close out** Accepts the final report and receives the network handoff. WF 10
LANE 3 — FedTech PM Where you focus at each stage	**Lock scope** Confirm in-scope workflows, ground rules and every gate with the COR.	**Launch** Get the site and Challenge.gov listing through their gates and live.	**Fill the pipeline** Run targeted outreach and matchmaking; track registrations weekly.	**Keep answers equal** Run the inbox, FAQ and webinar so every team gets the same answer.	**Protect the deadline** Keep the platform stable and send reminders; log late issues.	**Run review** Screen conflicts, run scoring and reconciliation, brief the judges.	**Coordinate release** Line up public affairs, winners and channels for one release.	**Produce the event** Deliver the convening and capture every introduction made.	**Report and hand off** Deliver final reports, the survey and the network handoff.

FOR THE PM

Plan for the shared moments.
Info session, webinar, announcement and convening are where solvers and the agency see our work together. Give them the most rehearsal.

Never leave a solver waiting silently.
Steps 05 to 07 feel longest to solvers. Publish the review timeline and keep to it.

Every client step is a gate or an input.
Match each one to its workflow sheet so the agency is never surprised by a request.

PHASE 1 · LAUNCH & VISIBILITY



WORKFLOW 01 OF 11

Website Build

SECTION 01 · BEFORE YOU START

Website Build

The dedicated challenge site is the front door for every solver. It carries the agency's identity, not ours, and handles registration, eligibility screening, submissions and judging. Every later workflow points back to it.

Best practices

01 **Lock the sitemap before anyone writes copy.** Scope creep on a challenge site starts in the page list.

02 **Book agency counsel time at kickoff.** Official rules review is usually the longest gate in the workflow.

03 **Design in agency identity from the first mockup.** Never show contractor branding to the client or to solvers.

04 **Run the Section 508 audit before the staging walkthrough.** The client should review an accessible site, not a list of fixes.

05 **Treat every post-launch rule change as a new gate.** It goes back through copy and rules approval, then to Challenge.gov.

CLIENT GATES 02 Sitemap · 03 Copy & rules · 04 Visual design · 07 Go-live

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 01 OF 11

Website Build

The dedicated challenge site carries the agency's identity, not ours. It handles registration, eligibility screening, submissions and judging. It's the first thing solvers see, and every later workflow points back to it.

FEDTECH LEAD	Challenge Operations Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency comms
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	Live, 508-compliant site

4 APPROVAL GATES

3 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Kickoff & requirements

- Confirm stage structure and public dates from the RFTP
- Collect agency brand guidelines and logo-use rules
- Agree on custom URL and hosting
- Inventory existing content and assets

CLIENT PROVIDES
Brand guidelines, logos, URL preference, key dates

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Sitemap & page plan

- Page list: Home, Challenge, Rules, Prizes, Timeline, FAQ, Resources, Register
- Map registration and submission flows for each stage
- Decide what is public and what sits behind login

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Sitemap, page list and user flows

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Copy & official rules

- Challenge narrative, eligibility, prize and timeline copy
- Official rules: IP, indemnification and liability terms
- Launch FAQ
- Plain-language pass on everything

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
All site copy, plus official rules after agency counsel review

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Visual design

- Wireframes for key page templates
- High-fidelity mockups in agency identity, not contractor branding
- Imagery selection and color contrast check

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Homepage and interior page mockups

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

05

Platform build & configuration

- Build approved pages on the challenge platform
- Registration, eligibility screening and versioned submission forms
- Reviewer portal and blinded scoring setup
- Analytics and inbox routing

CLIENT PROVIDES
Required submission fields and eligibility questions

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

QA & Section 508 audit

- Cross-browser and mobile checks
- Section 508 accessibility audit
- Test every form end to end
- Check links, typos and dates against approved copy

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Staging walkthrough & go-live

- Guided walkthrough of the staging site with the client
- One consolidated feedback round, then fixes
- Confirm launch date and announcement timing

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Go-live. Nothing publishes without it.

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

08

Launch & stage updates

- Publish and verify the live site
- Coordinate with the agency's announcement
- Post stage updates and keep the FAQ on a fixed schedule
- Rule changes go back through step 03

CLIENT PROVIDES
Announcement and press timing

Ops Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Sitemap
Locks scope before any copy is written

03 · Copy & rules
Needs agency counsel time; schedule it early

04 · Design
Approve mockups, not the built site

07 · Go-live
The final gate before solvers see anything

PHASE 1 · LAUNCH & VISIBILITY



WORKFLOW 02 OF 11

Challenge.gov Listing

SECTION 02 · BEFORE YOU START

Challenge.gov Listing

The official federal listing for the prize competition. It is usually published through the agency's own Challenge.gov account and points solvers to our site, so it must match the site at every stage.

Best practices

01 **Find the agency's Challenge.gov manager at kickoff.** Publishing usually runs through their account, not ours.

02 **Reuse approved site copy word for word.** Never write new rules language for the listing.

03 **Publish the listing and the site on the same day.** Solvers who find one should never land on a dead link to the other.

04 **Mirror every change on the site.** A date, prize amount or rule that changes on the site changes on Challenge.gov the same day.

05 **Close the loop at the end.** Post winners and close the listing so it never shows an open challenge that has ended.

CLIENT GATES 04 Listing review · 07 Stage & winner updates

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 02 OF 11

Challenge.gov Listing

The official federal listing for the prize competition. It is usually published through the agency's own Challenge.gov account and points solvers to our challenge site. It must stay in step with the site at every stage.

FEDTECH LEAD	Challenge Operations Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency Challenge.gov manager
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	Live listing, kept current

2 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Confirm the posting path

- Identify the agency's Challenge.gov manager and account
- Decide: full listing on Challenge.gov, or summary linking to our site
- Confirm the RFTP's posting requirements and dates

CLIENT PROVIDES
Challenge.gov contact, account access process, posting preference

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Draft listing content

- Adapt approved website copy to Challenge.gov's fields
- Summary, prizes, timeline, rules, judging criteria, how to enter
- External link to the challenge site

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

Listing assets

- Banner and logo images sized to Challenge.gov specs
- Alt text for every image
- Agency identity only, matching the site

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Client review of listing

- Send a preview of the full listing text and images
- Check that dates, prize amounts and rules match the site word for word
- One consolidated feedback round

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Final listing text and images

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

05

Agency publishes

- Agency manager enters or imports the listing
- Or grants FedTech access, if the agency allows it
- Schedule it to go live with the challenge site

CLIENT PROVIDES
The publish action on the agency account

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Launch-day check

- Verify the listing is live and every link works
- Cross-check dates and amounts against the site
- Share the listing URL with the outreach team

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Stage & winner updates

- Update the listing when each stage opens and closes
- Post winners once they are announced
- Close the listing at the end of the challenge

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Each update, including the winner posting

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

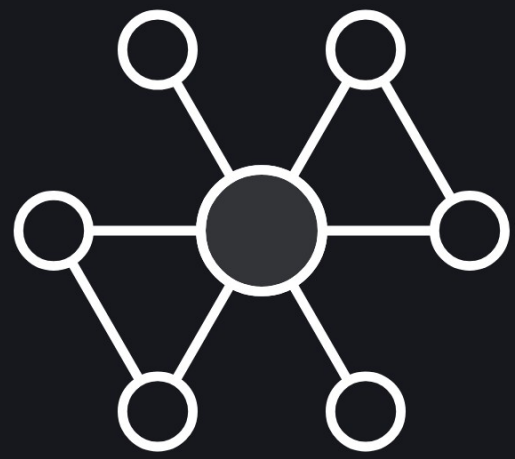
04 · Listing
Reuses approved site copy, so review should be quick

07 · Updates
Every change on the site needs a matching update here

Depends on: Website step 03 (copy & rules approved)

Publishing access varies by agency; confirm at kickoff

PHASE 1 · LAUNCH & VISIBILITY



WORKFLOW 03 OF 11

Outreach & Recruitment

SECTION 03 · BEFORE YOU START

Outreach & Recruitment

The plan and campaign that bring the right solvers in. The size and quality of the entrant pool is set here, long before judging, and it runs from launch through every stage's close.

Best practices

01 **Recruit from a named target list, not a broadcast.** Know which labs, companies and teams you need before the first send.

02 **Approve the content kit once, then reuse it.** One review covers every email, post and partner toolkit that follows.

03 **Treat matchmaking as a product.** A partner board, office hours and mixers turn interested individuals into credible teams.

04 **Measure reach into HBCUs, MSIs and EPSCoR institutions.** Report it monthly as a KPI, not as a promise.

05 **Shift effort weekly toward what converts.** Registrations by channel tell you where the next hour of outreach belongs.

CLIENT GATES 02 Outreach plan & KPIs · 03 Messaging & content kit

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 03 OF 11

Outreach & Recruitment

This is the plan and the campaign that bring the right solvers in. We recruit from a named target list, not a broadcast, and we track participation from underrepresented institutions as a measured result. It runs from launch through each stage's close.

FEDTECH LEAD	Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency comms
TYPICAL DURATION	Ongoing, each stage
FINAL OUTPUT	Registrations and teams formed

2 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Audience research & target list

- Map every solver community the challenge needs
- Build a named list of labs, companies and teams
- Find prior related-challenge participants
- Include HBCUs, MSIs and EPSCoR institutions

CLIENT PROVIDES
Known stakeholders, past participants, agency channels

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Outreach plan

- Goals and KPIs: registrations, submissions, diversity metrics
- Channel plan for each community
- Campaign calendar tied to stage dates
- Matchmaking plan for cross-discipline teams

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Outreach plan and KPI targets

Outreach Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Messaging & content kit

- Key messages for each audience
- Email templates, social posts and graphics
- Partner toolkit for societies and universities to share
- All drawn from approved site copy

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Messaging, templates and any use of agency name or logo

Outreach Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

04

Partner & channel engagement

- Brief professional societies and consortia
- Tech-transfer offices and the SBIR/STTR community
- Agency social channels and newsletters

CLIENT PROVIDES
Introductions to partners; posts on agency channels

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Campaign execution

- Direct outreach to the named target list
- Scheduled email and social sends
- Promote the info session and webinars
- Deadline reminders before each stage closes

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Matchmaking & team formation

- Partner-finding board on the challenge site
- Office hours
- Virtual mixers each stage
- Broker introductions across disciplines

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Tracking & adjustment

- Weekly registration and channel metrics
- Shift effort toward channels that convert
- Report KPIs, including diversity metrics, in monthly reports

Outreach Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

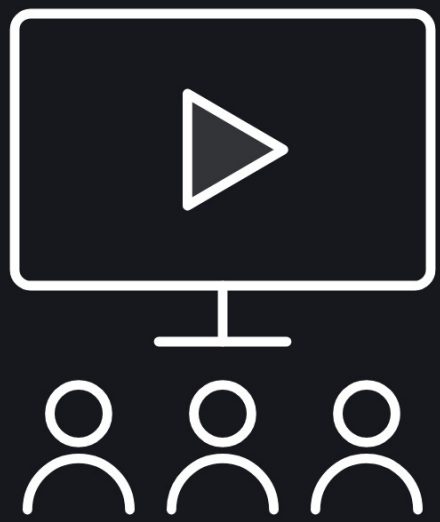
02 · Plan & KPIs
Agree on what success means before spending effort

03 · Content kit
Approve once, then reuse for every send

New messages outside the approved kit go back through step 03

Results feed into the monthly reports (Workflow 10)

PHASE 1 · LAUNCH & VISIBILITY



WORKFLOW 04 OF 11

Info Session

SECTION 04 · BEFORE YOU START

Info Session

A public live session for prospective solvers: what the challenge is, who can enter, what's at stake and how to apply. It is often the agency's most visible moment after launch, and the first time solvers hear from us directly.

Best practices

01 **Lock the speakers before promotion names them.** A changed speaker after the invite goes out means new copy and a new review.

02 **Build the deck from approved site copy.** Familiar language keeps the client's review short.

03 **Settle policy answers before going live.** Agree the hard eligibility answers with the client in the answer bank, not on air.

04 **Defer anything uncertain to writing.** "We'll answer that for everyone in the FAQ" is always a safe reply.

05 **Publish written answers to every question.** Teams that couldn't attend get the same information as those who did.

CLIENT GATES 02 Agenda & speakers · 03 Promotion · 04 Slide deck · 08 Follow-up

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 04 OF 11

Info Session Build

A public, live session for prospective solvers. It covers what the challenge is, who can enter, what's at stake and how to apply. It's often the agency's most visible moment after launch.

FEDTECH LEAD	Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency speakers
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	Session, recording, written Q&A

4 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Scope & logistics

- Date, time, length and target audience
- Platform choice (some agencies require their own)
- Registration method
- Live captioning and recording plan

CLIENT PROVIDES
Preferred dates, agency speakers, platform constraints

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Agenda & speakers

- Run of show, minute by minute
- Speaker roles: agency welcome, challenge overview, how to enter, Q&A
- Moderator and backup assigned

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Agenda and speaker lineup

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Promotion

- Registration page on the challenge site
- Email, social and newsletter copy
- Partner and channel outreach list
- Reminder sequence to registrants

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Promotional copy and any use of agency name or logo

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Slide deck

- Built from approved website copy, not new language
- Overview, timeline, eligibility, prizes, how to enter
- Speaker notes for each presenter
- 508-compliant slides

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Final deck: content and branding

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

05

Q&A preparation

- Anticipated questions from the inbox and FAQ log
- Draft answer bank
- Assign who answers which topics
- Route policy and eligibility questions to the client

CLIENT PROVIDES
Answers to policy and eligibility questions

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Dry run

- Full rehearsal with timing
- Agency speakers join
- Test captions, polls, recording and screen share
- Backup plan if a speaker drops

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Deliver the session

- Host and moderate
- Live captions and recording on
- Capture every question word for word
- Defer anything uncertain to the written follow-up

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

08

Post-event follow-up

- Edit recording; add captions and transcript
- Written answer to every question asked
- Update the site FAQ
- Attendance and registration report

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Recording, transcript and written answers before public posting

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Agenda
Locks speakers before promotion names them

03 · Promotion
Any use of the agency name needs approval

04 · Deck
Reuses approved site copy to keep the review short

08 · Follow-up
Written answers become public guidance

PHASE 2 · RUN THE COMPETITION



WORKFLOW 05 OF 11

Competitor Management

SECTION 05 · BEFORE YOU START

Competitor Management

FedTech is the single point of contact for every solver question, eligibility call and dispute. Most answers come from approved material; policy questions go to the client. Every answer either keeps the field level or tilts it.

Best practices

01 **Get the escalation matrix approved before launch.** Everyone should know which questions FedTech answers and which go to the client.

02 **Send the client a draft answer, not just the question.** A yes or a small edit comes back far faster than a blank page.

03 **Answer only from approved rules and FAQ.** Anything new is a rule interpretation and needs the client.

04 **Publish FAQ updates on a fixed schedule.** One team's question becomes everyone's answer at the same time.

05 **Log every inquiry and decision.** When a dispute comes, the record is your defense.

CLIENT GATES 01 Escalation rules · 04 FAQ updates · 06 Disputes

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 05 OF 11

Competitor Management

FedTech is the single point of contact for every solver question, eligibility determination and dispute. Most questions are answered from approved material. Policy questions go to the client, and every decision leaves a record.

FEDTECH LEAD	Challenge Operations Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR
TYPICAL DURATION	Launch to closeout
FINAL OUTPUT	Audit-ready inquiry record

3 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

01

Inbox & escalation rules

- Set up a monitored inbox and published response-time commitment
- Define which questions FedTech answers and which go to the client
- Write the dispute process against the published rules

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Escalation matrix, response standard and dispute process

Ops Lead — Review: [X] days

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Triage & respond

- Log every inquiry with a timestamp
- Answer from approved rules and FAQ only
- Route anything new or policy-related per the matrix

Ops Lead

○ CLIENT INPUT

03

Policy questions

- Send the client a draft answer, not just the question
- Hold the reply to the solver until the client responds
- Queue the answer for the next FAQ update

CLIENT PROVIDES
Decisions on policy and rule interpretation

Ops Lead

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

04

FAQ updates

- Batch new answers on a fixed schedule
- Post on the site so every solver sees the same answer
- Mirror to Challenge.gov if rules are affected

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
New FAQ entries that interpret the rules

Ops Lead — Review: [X] days

○ CLIENT INPUT

05

Eligibility determinations

- Screen registrants against the published eligibility rules
- Decide clear cases from the rules
- Send borderline cases to the client with a recommendation

CLIENT PROVIDES
Rulings on borderline eligibility cases

Ops Lead

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

06

Disputes

- Acknowledge the dispute and gather the facts
- Assess it against the published rules
- Draft a resolution with its rationale

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Each dispute resolution before it is sent

Ops Lead — Review: [X] days

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Records & metrics

- Audit-ready log of inquiries, decisions and disputes
- Response-time metrics
- Recurring questions flagged to improve site copy

Ops Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

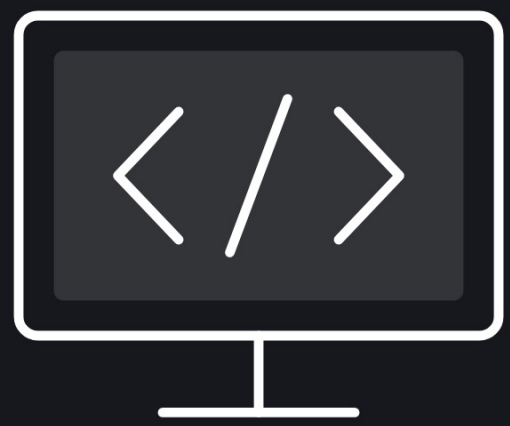
01 · Escalation rules
Set once at launch, so most answers need no review

04 · FAQ
Published answers act as rule guidance for everyone

06 · Disputes
The client stands behind every resolution

Recurring questions also feed the webinar topics (Workflow 06)

PHASE 2 · RUN THE COMPETITION



WORKFLOW 06 OF 11

Technical Webinar

SECTION 06 · BEFORE YOU START

Technical Webinar

A deeper session for registered teams, led by subject-matter experts, on the technical areas where solvers struggle most. Its biggest risk is a verbal clarification that the published rules don't support.

Best practices

01 **Pick topics from real confusion.** The inbox, FAQ log and early submissions show where teams are stuck.

02 **Screen presenters for judging conflicts first.** A reviewer who coaches teams on air can't score them later.

03 **Check every slide against the rules and rubric.** No new requirement should ever be introduced out loud.

04 **Keep a recorded fallback for every live demo.** Hardware and connections fail on the day.

05 **Turn every question into a written answer for all teams.** Client-approved, then posted, because it acts as a rule interpretation.

CLIENT GATES 02 Presenters · 03 Technical content · 07 Written Q&A

Full steps on the next sheet →

Technical Webinar

A deeper session for registered teams, led by subject-matter experts. It covers the technical areas where solvers struggle most. The risk is clarifying something verbally that the rules don't say, so the content gate matters most here.

FEDTECH LEAD	Review Lead + Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency technical leads
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	Webinar, recording, written Q&A

3 APPROVAL GATES

1 INPUT POINT

CLIENT INPUT

01

Define technical objectives

- Mine the inbox, FAQ log and early submissions for where solvers struggle
- Set two or three learning goals
- Pick a format: talks, live demo or panel

CLIENT PROVIDES
Technical priorities from the agency's technical leads

Review Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Presenters & conflict check

- Identify SMEs from the agency, partners and FedTech
- Screen against reviewer/judge roles and the entrant list
- Confirm availability and the presentation brief

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Presenter lineup

Review Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Technical content

- Presenters draft; FedTech fits it to the template and plain language
- Check every claim against the published rules and rubric
- No new requirements introduced verbally
- 508-compliant slides and demo materials

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Technical accuracy and consistency with official rules

Review Lead — Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Promotion to registered teams

- Targeted email to registrants and partner channels
- Reuse promotion templates already approved for the info session
- Add the webinar to the site's events page

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Rehearsal & demo check

- Timing run with every presenter
- Recorded fallback for any live demo
- Assign Q&A roles by topic
- Captioning and recording test

Review Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Deliver the webinar

- Host and moderate; SMEs field technical questions
- Capture every question word for word
- Rules or eligibility questions: "we'll answer in writing for everyone"

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Publish written Q&A

- Written answer to every question, posted for all solvers
- Recording, slides and transcript
- Update the site FAQ
- Attendance report

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Written answers. They act as rule interpretations.

Review Lead — Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Presenters
A judge who presents creates a conflict; screen first

03 · Content
The highest-risk gate: verbal content can change the rules

07 · Written Q&A
Keeps every team on equal footing

Promotion reuses approved templates, so it carries no new gate

PHASE 2 · RUN THE COMPETITION



WORKFLOW 07 OF 11

Judging & Technical Review

SECTION 07 · BEFORE YOU START

Judging & Technical Review

Expert reviewers score submissions against an approved rubric, and federal judges make every award decision. A fair, documented review is what makes the results defensible, and its dates drive the winner announcement.

Best practices

01 **Lock the rubric before the stage opens.** Never change criteria or weights once solvers are building to them.

02 **Recruit a bench deeper than the seats.** In a small expert field, a reviewer dropping out mid-stage is likely.

03 **Screen conflicts against the entrant list every stage.** New entrants bring new conflicts.

04 **Discuss divergent scores; don't average them away.** A wide split usually means the rubric or the reviewers saw something important.

05 **Federal judges decide; everyone else advises.** Keep the decision record so the agency can stand behind every award.

CLIENT GATES 01 Rubric & weights · 07 Federal judging

Full steps on the next sheet →

Judging & Technical Review

Expert reviewers score submissions against an approved rubric, and federal judges make every award decision. Marketing rarely touches this workflow, but its dates and outcomes drive the winner announcement.

FEDTECH LEAD	Review Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + federal judges
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks per stage
FINAL OUTPUT	Verified winners per stage

2 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

01

Rubric & scoring design

- Criteria and weights for each stage
- Scoring scale and guidance for reviewers
- Published judging criteria match the rubric

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Rubric and weights, before the stage opens

Review Lead Review: [X] days

○ CLIENT INPUT

02

Reviewer & judge recruitment

- Recruit SME reviewers for each technical area
- Apply designated-country rules (FAR 52.225-5) if required
- Bench deeper than the seats needed

CLIENT PROVIDES
Federal judge names and reviewer nominations

Review Lead

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

Conflict screening & onboarding

- Screen for conflicts against the entrant list every stage
- NDAs signed
- Rubric training before scoring opens

Review Lead

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Submission screening

- Check completeness and compliance
- Confirm eligibility of each entrant
- Assign reviewers on the platform

Ops Lead

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Independent scoring

- Blind, independent scores on the platform
- Track progress against the scoring deadline
- Replace a reviewer from the bench if one drops out

Review Lead

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Reconciliation

- Moderated session to discuss divergent scores
- Record of the discussion, not just averages
- Score packet prepared for federal judges

Review Lead

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Federal judging

- Brief judges on scores and reconciliation record
- Facilitate the judging session
- Document the decisions and their rationale

CLIENT DECIDES
Every award. Federal judges only.

Review Lead Review: [X] days

○ CLIENT INPUT

08

Winner verification & prize handoff

- Re-verify eligibility of each winner
- Collect payment information as the agency directs
- Hand the winner list to the announcement workflow

CLIENT PROVIDES
Prize payment (usually paid directly by the agency)

Ops Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

01 · Rubric
Locked before the stage opens, never mid-review

07 · Award decisions
Federal judges only; FedTech and SMEs advise

Marketing: winner names stay confidential until Workflow 08 clears them

Repeats every stage

PHASE 3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT



WORKFLOW 08 OF 11

Winner Announcement

SECTION 08 · BEFORE YOU START

Winner Announcement

The public moment for each stage's results. Agency public affairs usually controls timing and clearance. Our job is to have everything ready so the release goes out in the same hour on every channel.

Best practices

01 **Learn public affairs' clearance lead time at kickoff.** It is often the longest wait in the whole workflow.

02 **Draft content while judging is still underway.** Templates with placeholder names let clearance start before the winners are known.

03 **Get winner consent before release.** Names, quotes, photos and affiliations should all be confirmed by the teams.

04 **Release everywhere in the same hour.** Site, Challenge.gov, social and email go out together.

05 **Route media inquiries to public affairs.** FedTech supports the story; the agency tells it.

CLIENT GATES 03 Announcement content

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 08 OF 11

Winner Announcement

The public moment for each stage's results. The agency's public affairs office usually controls timing and clearance. Our job is to have everything ready so the release goes out the same hour on every channel.

FEDTECH LEAD	Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency public affairs
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks per stage
FINAL OUTPUT	Coordinated public release

1 APPROVAL GATE

1 INPUT POINT

CLIENT INPUT

01

Announcement plan

- Target date, embargo and channel list
- Learn public affairs' clearance steps and lead time
- Decide who announces: agency, FedTech or both

CLIENT PROVIDES
Public affairs contact, clearance timeline, preferred date

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Notify winners privately

- Notify winners under embargo
- Collect bios, photos and team details
- Notify non-winners on the same day as the public release

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Announcement content

- Press release or blog post
- Winner profiles and site update
- Social posts and graphics
- Challenge.gov winner posting

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
All announcement content, through public affairs clearance

Outreach Lead Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Winner consent

- Winners confirm their profiles and any quotes
- Photo and name-use permissions on file
- Confirm affiliations are spelled correctly

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Coordinated release

- Publish site, Challenge.gov and social together
- Email registrants and partners
- Verify every link once live

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Amplification

- Partner newsletters and society channels
- Reuse approved content only
- Route media inquiries to agency public affairs

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Results reporting

- Reach and engagement metrics
- Press pickup log
- Included in the stage-close report

Outreach Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

03 · Content
Public affairs clearance often takes longest; start it early

Depends on: Judging step 07 (awards decided)

Winner names are confidential until release

Repeats every stage

PHASE 3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT



WORKFLOW 09 OF 11

In-Person Convening

SECTION 09 · BEFORE YOU START

In-Person Convening

An in-person event where winners present and meet the funders, adopters and program staff who can carry their work forward. Not every task order includes one, but when it does, it is the most visible deliverable.

Best practices

01 **Confirm scope and budget before planning.** Know what the task order covers, such as staff travel versus participant travel.

02 **Get venue and date approved before signing anything.** Venue contracts are the hardest commitment to undo.

03 **Design the agenda for what happens next.** Put winners in front of funders, adopters and SBIR/STTR staff, not just an audience.

04 **Coach winners on their presentations.** A rehearsed five-minute pitch does more for them than the award itself.

05 **Capture and hand off every introduction.** The contacts made in the room belong to the agency's network afterward.

CLIENT GATES 02 Venue · 03 Agenda · 05 Materials · 08 Recap

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 09 OF 11

In-Person Convening

An in-person event where winners present and meet the people who can carry their work forward: funders, adopters and program staff. Not every task order includes one. When it does, it is the most visible deliverable.

FEDTECH LEAD	Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + program leadership
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] months
FINAL OUTPUT	Event, recap, contact handoff

4 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Goals & format

- What the event must achieve beyond showcasing
- Attendance target and audience mix
- Length, region and date window

CLIENT PROVIDES
Goals, date constraints, leadership availability

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Venue & logistics

- Shortlist venues near agency stakeholders
- AV, catering and physical accessibility
- Budget check: what the task order covers

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Venue and date, before contracting

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Agenda & speakers

- Winner presentations
- Sessions with funders, SBIR/STTR staff and adopters
- Agency leadership remarks
- Structured networking time

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Agenda and speaker lineup

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

04

Invitations & registration

- Build the invite list
- Registration page and confirmations
- Travel details for winners, if covered

CLIENT PROVIDES
Agency invitees and VIPs

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

05

Event materials

- Printed program and signage
- Slide template and name badges
- Accessible digital versions

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
All branded and printed materials

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Run of show & rehearsal

- Minute-by-minute run of show
- Winner presentation coaching
- AV walkthrough on site

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Deliver the event

- Staff registration and sessions
- Photography and recording, with consent
- Capture contacts and introductions made

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

08

Follow-up & recap

- Attendee survey
- Public recap: blog, photos, video
- Hand off contacts and introductions to the agency

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Public recap content before posting

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Venue
Approve before signing any venue contract

03 · Agenda
Locks leadership calendars early

05 · Materials
Print deadlines drive this review window

08 · Recap
Public content, same rule as every other workflow

PHASE 3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT



WORKFLOW 10 OF 11

Reporting & Closeout

SECTION 10 · BEFORE YOU START

Reporting & Closeout

The contractual record of the challenge, from kickoff to the post-award evaluation survey. It runs behind every other workflow for the whole period of performance, and it is how the COR sees our work.

Best practices

01 **Use kickoff to set every gate.** Name a client reviewer and a review window for each one, in writing.

02 **Raise any slip with options, not just a warning.** A risk to a public date reaches the COR with a recommended fix.

03 **Feed metrics in as you go.** Outreach, inquiry and review numbers should flow into monthly reports, not be rebuilt each month.

04 **Ask early about Paperwork Reduction Act clearance.** If the post-award survey needs it, clearance can take months.

05 **Build the network handoff as you go.** Keep the SME roster and stakeholder contacts current, not reconstructed at closeout.

CLIENT GATES 01 Project plan · 03 Monthly reports · 04 Stage-close reports · 07 Final report

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 10 OF 11

Reporting & Closeout

The contractual record of the challenge, from kickoff to the post-award evaluation survey. It runs in the background of every other workflow. The metrics marketing collects end up here.

FEDTECH LEAD	Program Manager
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR
TYPICAL DURATION	Full period of performance
FINAL OUTPUT	Final report + network handoff

4 APPROVAL GATES

1 INPUT POINT

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

01

Kickoff & project plan

- Kickoff with the COR soon after award
- Baselined schedule with every public date
- Report templates and meeting cadence
- Named reviewer and review window for every gate

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Project plan, schedule and report formats

PM — Review: [X] days

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Status calls

- Weekly during active stages; biweekly otherwise
- Upcoming gates and decisions needed
- Any slip on a public date raised with options

PM

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Monthly progress reports

- Participation and outreach metrics
- Review status, risks and spend
- Inquiry volume and response times

CLIENT ACCEPTS
Each monthly report

PM — Review: [X] days

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Stage-close reports

- Submissions, scoring and winners
- Outreach and announcement results
- Lessons learned for the next stage

CLIENT ACCEPTS
Each stage-close report

PM — Review: [X] days

○ CLIENT INPUT

05

Post-award evaluation survey

- Survey of winners and participants after the final award
- Ask the client whether Paperwork Reduction Act clearance is needed
- Results summarized for the final report

CLIENT PROVIDES
Questions the agency needs answered

PM

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Network handoff package

- SME and reviewer roster
- Stakeholder and partner contacts
- Challenge records and platform data export

PM

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Final report & closeout

- Full challenge results and outcomes
- Evaluation survey findings
- Recommendations for future challenges
- Close the site and listing per the agency's wishes

CLIENT ACCEPTS
Final report, including the network handoff package

PM — Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

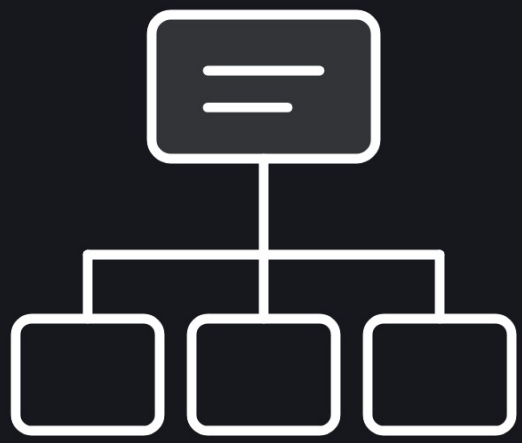
01 · Project plan
Sets every other workflow's review windows

03 · Monthly reports
Marketing metrics feed in here

04 · Stage-close
One per stage, after winners are announced

07 · Final report
Closes the task order

ACROSS ALL PHASES



WORKFLOW 11 OF 11

Subcontractor Management

SECTION 11 · BEFORE YOU START

Subcontractor Management

Partners extend what FedTech can deliver, but FedTech stays fully responsible for their work. This workflow runs from the proposal to closeout, alongside every other workflow in the playbook.

Best practices

01 **Flow down every obligation FedTech carries.** Section 508, designated-country rules, conflict of interest, NDA and data rights all go into the subcontract.

02 **The client and CoECI hear one voice: FedTech's.** Subs never contact either one directly without us.

03 **Review sub work before the client sees it.** Their deliverable is our deliverable.

04 **Track the work share monthly.** Confirm FedTech performs more than half the work while there is still time to correct it.

05 **Never change a named sub without approval.** The client agency approves in writing, with CoECI copied.

CLIENT GATES 02 Named subs at award · 06 Any change to a sub

Full steps on the next sheet →

Subcontractor Management

How FedTech brings partners onto a task order and keeps them accountable. FedTech holds full responsibility for everything a subcontractor delivers, and the client and CoECI hear one voice: ours.

FEDTECH LEAD	Program Manager
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR, CoECI copied
TYPICAL DURATION	Proposal to closeout
FINAL OUTPUT	Sub work delivered and closed

2 APPROVAL GATES

0 INPUT POINTS

FEDTECH INTERNAL

01

Identify & vet partner

- Confirm the capability gap the partner fills
- Conflict-of-interest check
- Confirm they can accept every flow-down clause
- Teaming agreement before the proposal

PM

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Disclose in proposal

- Name, role and value of each sub
- Relationship and prior work together
- Show FedTech performs more than half the work

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON

The named subcontractors, through the award

PM — At award

FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

Execute subcontract

- Fixed price, defined deliverables, milestone payments
- Flow-downs: Section 508, FAR 52.225-5, conflict of interest, NDA, data rights
- Signed at task order award

PM + contracts

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Onboard

- Kickoff: who does what, by when
- Agency branding only
- CoECI's six expectations apply to sub staff too
- No direct contact with the client or CoECI without FedTech

PM

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Manage delivery

- Weekly check-ins against milestones
- FedTech reviews every sub deliverable before the client sees it
- Escalate slips early

PM

CLIENT APPROVAL

06

Changes to a sub

- Replacing, adding or dropping a sub
- Changing a sub's scope or key staff
- Request in writing to the COR, CoECI copied

CLIENT AGENCY SIGNS OFF ON

Any change to a named sub, its scope or key staff

PM — Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Invoice & track work share

- Pay on accepted milestones only
- Confirm each month that FedTech performs more than half the work

PM + finance

FEDTECH INTERNAL

08

Closeout

- Final deliverables accepted
- Records, data and access returned
- Performance review feeds the final report

PM

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Named subs
Accepted by the client agency as part of the award

06 · Any change
Client agency approval, in writing, CoECI copied

Runs from proposal to closeout, alongside every other workflow

Subs never speak for FedTech with the client or CoECI

WORKFLOW [NN] OF [NN]

[Workflow name]

[One or two sentences: what this workflow produces, who it is for, and why the client cares about it.]

FEDTECH LEAD	[Role]
CLIENT COUNTERPART	[Role]
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	[Deliverable]

[N] APPROVAL GATES

[N] INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

CLIENT PROVIDES
[What we need from the client]

[Owner]

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
[The exact deliverable being approved]

[Owner] Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

[Owner]

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

[Owner]

CLIENT APPROVAL

05

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
[The exact deliverable being approved]

[Owner] Review: [X] days

HOW TO USE THIS TEMPLATE

Duplicate this artboard and rename it.

Copy a card of the right type for each step. Push each new card down by another 48 px to keep the diagonal.

Name what the client signs off on in every approval card. "Review the draft" isn't enough.

Update the gate and input counts, the gate sequence below, and the overview sheet.

Delete this note.

GATE SEQUENCE

[NN] · [Gate]
[Why this gate sits here]

[NN] · [Gate]
[Why this gate sits here]

[NN] · [Gate]
[Why this gate sits here]

[NN] · [Gate]
[Why this gate sits here]